

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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SESSION SIX

Forgiving Others and Yourself

Optional session: for the at-home format, the 30-day follow-up, or a supported setting. Not part of the standard three-day schedule.

Before you begin

This session is optional, and it is not in the standard three-day program. Sessions Four and Five both said it may be deferred, and the three-day schedule in Part Four does not include it. It belongs in the at-home format, where it has its own day; in the 30-day plan in Part Five; or in a supported setting with a pastor, counsellor, or trauma-informed professional. Read this section and decide honestly whether now is the time.

Consider proceeding if you are sufficiently rested and settled, the harm is no longer active, and you want to explore what forgiveness might mean without forcing a final outcome. Defer for any reason that makes today feel unsuitable. You do not need to prove that your reason is valid.

If the harm you carry is abuse, Chapter 5's guidance applies throughout. You are not required to forgive on a schedule, you are never required to contact or return to someone who harmed you, and the default exercise at the end is written specifically with you in mind. If exercises involving the person who harmed you tend to trigger panic, flashbacks, or dissociation, plan this

session with a trauma-informed professional rather than doing it alone. If someone monitors your belongings or writing, do not create or keep anything that could place you at risk; pray without writing.

Five movements, not one

Much of the confusion around forgiveness comes from asking one word to do five different jobs. This session separates them, and the rest of it will use these terms.

Movement	Meaning
Truth	Naming the wrong without minimising it
Safety	Ending exposure to continuing harm
Justice	Reporting, restitution, consequences, and protection
Release	Relinquishing personal vengeance and the compulsion to collect
Reconciliation	Possible only with repentance, safety, and rebuilt trust

You can unilaterally relinquish personal vengeance, pray for freedom from hatred, establish boundaries, and entrust judgement to God. Some Christians call that forgiveness; others reserve "forgiveness" for a relational response to repentance. This guide uses "release" for the unilateral decision and "reconciliation" for a restored relationship. Reconciliation always requires more than one person. Release, truth, safety, and justice do not wait for the other person.

Central passage

Matthew 18:21–35

Read it twice. The second time, notice both the mercy and the warning.

Teaching

Peter asked Jesus how many times he should forgive his brother, and suggested seven, which he apparently regarded as a generous number. Jesus' answer, seventy-seven or seventy times seven depending on the translation, refuses to turn forgiveness into a tally. Then he told a story.

A servant owes a king ten thousand talents. A talent represented an enormous amount, commonly estimated at many years of a labourer's income, and ten thousand of them creates an intentionally impossible debt. The king forgives it entirely. The same servant then finds a fellow servant who owes him a hundred denarii, still a substantial sum, roughly a hundred days' wages, but tiny beside the first amount, and has him thrown into prison. The king hears of it, and the story ends with a severe warning.

The parable contains both extravagant mercy and that warning, and both need to be held. The warning should never be used to coerce traumatised people into declaring forgiveness on demand. Yet Jesus does confront the contradiction of receiving mercy while cultivating a settled refusal to extend mercy to others. That challenge must be heard within the larger biblical framework of repentance, justice, safety, and patient spiritual formation, not as a threat hanging over a wounded person. We do not purchase God's grace by performing forgiveness correctly. At the same time, Jesus treats a merciless heart as spiritually serious. Christians have differed over how repentance relates to interpersonal forgiveness, but Scripture consistently forbids personal vengeance and calls believers toward mercy. **Colossians 3:13** puts it this way: "as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also

must forgive." The mercy you have received is the starting point, not a debt you must now repay by forgiving.

It is worth noticing what comes just before the parable. **Matthew 18:15–17** describes a process for dealing with a brother who has sinned against you: go to him, then take witnesses, then involve the community. Forgiveness in Matthew 18 sits inside a framework of truth-telling and accountability. It is not the same as pretending nothing happened. But these steps are not a universal procedure for abuse, criminal conduct, coercive control, or situations involving unequal power. In such cases, do not begin with private confrontation. Seek specialist, safeguarding, legal, or law-enforcement guidance as appropriate.

Now let me say plainly what release is not, because most of the reasons people cannot forgive are really reasons they cannot do something else that has been wrongly called forgiveness.

It is not saying the harm did not matter. Truth comes first. You cannot release a debt that was never owed, and you are invited to trust that God sees the wrong truthfully and does not require you to deny its seriousness.

It is not forgetting. Joseph, in **Genesis 50:15–21**, eventually rejected vengeance, reassured his brothers, and provided for them, and he remembered every detail: "you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good." Remembering is not the opposite of releasing.

It is not reconciliation. Genesis 42–44 shows Joseph testing his brothers at length, with truth coming to light and evidence of change, before the relationship was openly restored. Genesis does not tell us the moment Joseph inwardly released them, so we should not assign an order it does not give. But the story resists the idea that mercy requires immediate trust.

It is not the removal of safety, boundaries, or justice. You can release personal vengeance and still not let the person near your children, still report what they did, still leave, still refuse to work with them again. Release relinquishes vengeance and the desire to inflict suffering for its own sake. It does not necessarily surrender a legitimate claim to restitution, compensation, repayment, reporting, or legal remedy. Those may be part of justice and protection rather than revenge. **Romans 12:19** forbids personal vengeance: "never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God." It does not remove public justice; in the next chapter Paul describes governing authority as accountable for responding to wrongdoing (Romans 13:1-4). Leaving vengeance to God does not mean preventing lawful authorities, churches, employers, or safeguarding bodies from carrying out their responsibilities.

It is not reducible to a feeling, and it is not always completed by one decision. Release may involve an initial choice against vengeance, repeated prayer, grief, changes in desire, and a long process of healing. Feelings do not have to change on command. And the return of pain or anger does not prove that release failed or must be performed again. A memory can hurt after a genuine decision against vengeance. Respond to what the memory needs, grief, grounding, boundaries, treatment, or renewed prayer, without turning forgiveness into a repetitive test.

It is not required to be spoken to the person. In many cases it should not be. Release is between you and God. Whether the other person ever knows is a separate question, and sometimes the answer is that they must not.

A word about "forgiving yourself." Scripture does not quite use the phrase, and the difference matters. You are not the judge in your own case. What you can do is receive the verdict God has given: "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who

are in Christ Jesus" (**Romans 8:1**). Even after receiving forgiveness, a person may continue to feel guilt or shame. That does not automatically mean they are rejecting God. They may need time, restitution, pastoral care, or professional help to integrate what forgiveness means. It helps to separate four things. Healthy conviction identifies wrongdoing and moves toward confession and repair. Shame says the whole person is beyond grace. Consequences address what must still be repaired or protected. Self-punishment attempts to pay for guilt through suffering. In Christian terms, "forgiving yourself" can mean ceasing deliberate self-punishment, accepting that God's mercy is not earned through continued misery, and undertaking repair without making suffering into payment.

Finally, about people who have died, or who are gone, or who will never acknowledge what they did. Release does not require them. It happens before God, whether or not the other person is in the room.

Self-assessment

Gently, in your journal:

1. Is there a person whose actions still carry unresolved grief, anger, fear, or a desire for justice in you? Name them, or use an initial, or write nothing identifying.
2. Which of those responses needs grief, which needs protection, which needs accountability, and which may be moving toward release? Use the five movements.
3. Which parts of what you want depend on the other person? Which faithful steps remain available to you even if they never respond as you hope?
4. Is there something you have been punishing yourself for that God has already forgiven, or that you have never brought to

him? If any of this brings up more than you can hold, stop, and defer the session. That is a legitimate decision.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

*Lord, I have received mercy I could never earn.
I also carry a real wrong committed against me, and it
has caused real harm. _____ did _____.
It was wrong.
I am not going to pretend it was not.
Where I have wanted them to suffer for it, I ask you to
take that from me.
I keep the boundaries I need.
I do not owe them my trust.
I will not abandon justice.
Do in me what I cannot do in myself.
And where I have been paying for my own guilt with
suffering, help me to stop.
Show me the next faithful step.
Amen.*

Silence

Suggested length: ten minutes, or the length you can manage.
This is deliberately short.

Anchor phrase: **"Into your hands I place this wound."** Or: **"God sees and God cares."** Or: **"Show me the next faithful step."**

Rest in the truth that God is both merciful and just. You do not need to compare the wrong done to you with anything else. Hold only the prayer.

If the silence brings the person's presence too close, if it moves into fear, panic, or reliving rather than remembering, stop, open your eyes, and use the orientation exercise from Chapter 5. That is not failure. It is information that this session needs support, and it can wait.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What happened in the silence? Write it without interpreting it.
2. Which of the "release is not" statements did you most need to hear? Which have you been confusing with forgiveness, and how has that confusion kept you from it?
3. What safety measure, boundary, report, or consequence will remain in place whatever you release? Write it down. Naming it may make release possible.
4. If you have been punishing yourself, which of the four (conviction, shame, consequence, self-punishment) is actually at work? What would it mean to accept Romans 8:1 as the verdict?

Practical exercise

The default exercise. Write only this, or pray it without writing, and let it be the whole exercise:

*God, I place this wound in your care and ask for help
with the next faithful step.*

That is not a lesser prayer. It is a complete one, and for many readers it is the only honest one available. The next faithful step

may be a counsellor, a safety plan, a report, a boundary, or simply rest. God is not waiting for you to forgive before he cares for the wound.

The optional further stage, for readers who are ready and safe. Take an index card and write, in your own words or in this shape:

*Today, as far as I am able, I release personal vengeance
and place justice in God's hands.*

*This does not surrender safety, truth, restitution,
reporting, or lawful accountability.*

I do not promise what I cannot yet give.

*If the pain returns, I will not assume this prayer failed;
I will ask whether I need lament, support, protection,
treatment, or renewed trust.*

I ask for help with the next faithful step.

Use an initial or no details. Read it to God. Do not send it, do not read it to the person, and do not write anything that would be unsafe for someone else to find. Put it in an envelope, seal it, and write on the front *Placed in God's care* and today's date. Nothing is destroyed.

If Session Five left you with something to release in yourself, a second card:

God has forgiven _____.

I have been responding through _____.

*Help me distinguish faithful accountability from self-
punishment.*

What repair is mine, I will pursue.

What suffering I am using as payment, help me release.

Seal it in the same envelope.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

I am not required to deny the wrong or abandon justice.

I release, or ask for help releasing, personal vengeance.

I will preserve the boundaries, truth, reporting, and accountability that remain necessary.

I place what I cannot control into God's care.

God's mercy does not require me to remain in danger.

Notes

Space for anything else you want to record from this session.

After Session Six: whatever you did or did not release today, take a break before anything else, and be kind to yourself in it. If you deferred the session, record the next form of support you want, not a deadline for forgiveness: a conversation with a counsellor, a strengthened boundary, a report, further grieving, or simply revisiting the question when you feel safer. If it would help and is safe, tell your support person that you deferred. You do not need to identify the person or disclose the details.

If this session brought the person who harmed you too close, or reopened something that feels dangerous, contact your support person and, if the harm is ongoing, a domestic-abuse service or the appropriate professional. If the person has access to children, vulnerable adults, ministry members, patients, students, employees, or others who may be at risk, forgiveness must never replace safeguarding and reporting; seek the appropriate specialist or authority. Forgiveness is never a reason to stay in harm's way, and no part of this retreat asks you to.